Chapter 14 – The Maratha Empire

Since the conquest of Arabs and Persians in sections of the country from about the 11th century, Islam had been an increasingly important part of the cultural landscape, but that wasn't India's first brush with Muslim people. As early as the 7th century, Muslim traders and immigrants had been part of the land. Cheraman Juma, believed to have been the very first Islamic mosque in India, was built in 629 CE.

Believers in the Prophet Muhammad, Muslims brought their own holy book, the Quran, with them to India. The holy text spoke of the Five Pillars of Islam: the only God is Allah, and his last messenger on Earth was Muhammad; pray five times a day while facing the holy city of Mecca; those with adequate means must give to the poor; Muslims must fast during the ninth month of the year, Ramadan; and those who are able to visit Mecca must do so in the twelfth month of the year.

India was a land of diverse religious beliefs—including various Hindu sects, Buddhism, Jainism, and Sikhism—and therefore, peaceful Muslim traders were perfectly welcome among them. In a country of many gods, one more did not pose much of a challenge. The Delhi Sultanate and then the Mughals brought hundreds of thousands more Muslims into India and built empires whose hierarchy was crowned by members of the Islamic church.

Starting in the 17th century, the Indian subcontinent fell back into the hands of the Hindus, who considered themselves the true and natural inhabitants of India. These were the Maratha. The fall of the Mughals and the rise of their political subordinates was quite accidental since the Maratha were a class of warrior Hindus who were trained by their Mughal masters for military campaigns. It was thanks to the persistence of Chhatrapati Shivaji that the massively oppressed Hindus of the Indian subcontinent were able to come together and eke out a portion of India for themselves.

Shivaji was a member of the elite Maratha clan, and as such, he enjoyed a relatively privileged life despite his Hindu heritage. Due to his aristocracy, Shivaji was able to muster an army and give Hindus hope for restitution of a land in which Hindus ruled over themselves. Shivaji intended to free the enslaved and oppressed alike and turn them to his own cause. 1645/1646 are significant years because this is when Shivaji captured Torna Fort, the first fort he captured which became the foundation of the Maratha Empire.